

the latest in a series of civil wars, which exhausted the Roman state. It was left powerless to resist the rise to absolute power of Caesar's great-nephew Octavian. Taking the title Augustus, Octavian created a new political arrangement that enabled him to rule as emperor, bringing the 500-year-old Roman Republic to an end in all but name.

Republican origins

From its ancient beginnings as a cluster of small villages on seven hills by the Tiber River, Rome grew into a city-state that was just one of many on the Italian peninsula. According to legend, Rome was first ruled by kings, but in 509 BCE, the monarchy was overthrown and it became a republic. A new constitution allowed the election of two top officials, known as consuls, to run the state, but in order to prevent abuse of power, their term was limited to one year. The office of king was also prohibited, and special provision was made for the appointment of a dictator to replace the consuls in times of crisis—his term being limited to six months.

The fledgling Roman Republic proved remarkably successful: between 500 and 300 BCE, it increased its extent and power through a combination of conquest and diplomacy until it incorporated the whole of Italy. Between 202 and 120 BCE, Rome came to dominate parts of North Africa, the Iberian Peninsula, Greece, and what is now southern France. Its conquered territories were organized into provinces, ruled by short-term governors who maintained order and oversaw the collection of taxes.

By the 1st century BCE, Rome was a Mediterranean superpower, yet its long tradition of collective government, in which no individual could gain too much control, was being challenged by the personal ambitions of a few immensely powerful military men. A series of bloody civil wars, internal political struggles, and civil unrest culminated with the dictatorship of Julius Caesar, a brilliant general and statesman, whose murder at the hands of his political enemies led to the demise of the republic and the birth of the Roman Empire.

The republic crumbles

In the period in which Julius Caesar came to prominence on the Roman political scene (around 70 BCE), Rome was in turmoil: beset with ever worsening social and economic problems and torn by political conflict. Early in Rome's history, the non-enlarged population had been officially split into two classes: the patricians (members of the ancient hereditary nobility and wealthy landowners) and the plebeians, or plebs for short (the common people). On the formation of the republic, only patricians had been entitled to hold office in the Senate—Rome's governing and advisory council—but in 368–367 BCE, a constitutional amendment allowed the election of wealthier plebs, too, and the result was a power-sharing arrangement.

However, in reality, a small group of patrician families known as the Optimates (the "Best Men") had long dominated the Senate and jealously guarded their privileges. In the late Roman Republic, those who championed the rights of the plebs—the Populares (the "People's Men")—sought popular support against the Optimates, either in the interests of the people themselves, or more often, in pursuit of their own careers. The self-interested Optimates resisted making the social and economic reforms that were urgently required to meet the changing needs of the Roman people. In Italy and the provinces an unequal system of taxation and corrupt governance were causing social unrest, while in the city of Rome itself, the infrastructure was barely able to cope with a growing population. The empire's rapid expansion had brought a flood of enslaved labor from the provinces, driving many Roman farm workers and smallholders off the land and into the city in search of work.

The rise of Julius Caesar

Meanwhile, a handful of military leaders in Rome's provinces had begun to use their armies to jockey for political prominence. Among them was Julius Caesar, a highly intelligent and ambitious general from a patrician family who had aligned himself with the Populares and risen swiftly through the political ranks. Caesar was »